Through a Parkdale Lens: Newcomer Families' Access to and Use of Child Care Support Resources in Toronto: Methodology

November 6, 2026

Through a Parkdale Lens: Newcomer Families' Access to and Use of Child Care Support Resources in Toronto: Methodology

Research Methodology

I will use a qualitative methodology to explore how newcomer families at one Toronto child care centre learn about, understand, and use or do not use the family support resources that the centre offers or refers. Qualitative research studies a small number of participants in depth so that the researcher can gather detailed accounts of one central phenomenon (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). This depth suits my central question, which asks how newcomer families describe their experiences of accessing and using or not using these resources. A family's path to a resource has many small steps, such as reading a notice, asking an educator, or deciding that a form is too hard. Open conversations can bring out these details, while fixed survey items would likely miss them.

Context is the second reason for this choice. Qualitative researchers study people in the settings where their experiences happen (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). All families in this study will deal with the same centre, the same City subsidy rules, and the same referral routes. They will do so in different languages and after different migration journeys. These conditions shape access, so I will describe them alongside the families' accounts.

The third reason is meaning-making. Grounded in constructivism, qualitative research seeks to understand how people make meaning of their social realities (Mwita, 2022). My literature review found that many parents who had heard of the new national child care system held limited or incorrect information about it (Burns et al., 2025). How a family interprets such information shapes whether it uses a resource. Interviews will let me hear how each family makes sense of eligibility rules and educators' explanations and how it reaches a decision. Families may understand the same rules in different ways, and these differences will add depth to the data.

Because I will be the main instrument of data collection, I must state my position (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). I am a Registered Early Childhood Educator who completed a

field placement at the study centre. There, I saw a parent mistake the City's subsidy waitlist for the centre's enrollment waitlist, which prompted this study. Since I know these procedures well, I may assume that they are clear to families. I will keep a reflexive journal to record such assumptions and my research decisions, which will help me manage bias (Mwita, 2022).

Research Design

I will use a qualitative descriptive design. Qualitative description aims to give a full summary of events in the everyday language of the people who experienced them (Sandelowski, 2000, as cited in Hall & Liebenberg, 2024). Researchers who use this design stay close to participants' words and keep interpretation low, so the findings reflect what participants actually said. The design also studies experiences in their natural setting, without variables or a theory chosen in advance (Hall & Liebenberg, 2024).

This design fits my study for three reasons. First, a design should follow from the research question (Villamin et al., 2025). My sub-questions ask families what helped or limited them, who explained the steps, and how educators responded to their language and cultural needs. These practical questions call for clear and detailed description. Second, qualitative description suits studies that need information directly from the people affected and that have limited time and resources (Hall & Liebenberg, 2024). A single-centre student project completed within one term fits that description. Third, findings that stay close to participants' words can inform practice (Villamin et al., 2025). Educators at the centre could use them to see where their explanations and referrals help families and where they fall short. Ilumin (2023) used the same design to describe immigrant families' child care experiences in Edmonton.

Participants, Recruitment and Sampling Plan

Participants and Recruitment

Participants

The participants will be four newcomer parents or primary caregivers. I define a newcomer family as an immigrant or refugee family with young children that has lived in Canada for five years or less (Massing et al., 2024). Each participant must (a) be 18 or older, (b)

have arrived in Canada within the past five years, in any immigration category, (c) have a child enrolled at the study centre, (d) have been offered or referred at least one family support resource by the centre in the past 12 months, such as the City of Toronto child care fee subsidy, EarlyON, or settlement services, and (e) be able to take part in English or Mandarin, or with an interpreter.

These criteria select parents with direct and recent experience of the resources my questions ask about. Criterion (d) includes parents whether or not they went on to use the resource, because my literature review showed that being offered a resource does not mean using it. I will explore each family's account on its own terms. The study will not divide families into users and non-users, and it will not compare them.

I will exclude families from the room where I completed my placement and families of centre staff. My earlier role, or a parent's employment at the centre, could make these families feel obliged to take part (Villamin et al., 2025). I will also not ask about immigration status. Fee subsidy applications require tax documents that undocumented families often cannot provide (Schmidt, 2026), and questions about status could discourage families from joining.

Recruitment Setting

I will recruit at a licensed child care centre in the Parkdale neighbourhood of west Toronto, where I completed my field placement. To protect families' privacy, I will not name the centre in this proposal or in any report. I chose this setting for two reasons. The centre already offers and refers family support resources, so its families have the experiences my questions ask about. Toronto's service plan also names child care settings as access points and identifies tax-filing requirements as a barrier to fee subsidy (Toronto Children's Services, 2025). A study in one centre can show how these city policies reach families. My placement gives me access to the centre, which makes recruitment feasible within the course timeline.

Recruitment Methods

I will first obtain approval from the George Brown Polytechnic Research Ethics Board (Canadian Institutes of Health Research et al., 2022) and written permission from the centre director. I will not contact any family before both are in place. I will then prepare a one-page

flyer and a letter of information in plain English and translate them into Mandarin and other languages common at the centre. The materials will explain the purpose of the study, the total time of about 60 to 75 minutes in one meeting, the voluntary nature of taking part, the $25 gift card, and how to reach me.

The director will share the invitation through the parent newsletter, the notice board, and family cubbies, and staff will not approach families in person. As in Hardware et al. (2026), someone other than the lead researcher will distribute the invitation to avoid a conflict of interest. A notice from the director could still feel like a request from the centre. The flyer will therefore state that the centre will not know who takes part and that the decision will not affect any child's care. Interested parents will contact me directly by email, phone, or text. A 10-minute call will confirm eligibility, and parents will have at least 48 hours to decide after they receive the consent form. If fewer than four parents respond by the middle of Week 1, the director will send one reminder.

Sampling Plan

Sampling Strategy. I will use purposive sampling, in which the researcher intentionally selects people who can help to understand the central phenomenon (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). Here, that means newcomer parents whom the centre has offered or referred a resource. The sample will also be a convenience sample, because I will recruit willing and available parents at a centre I can already reach (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). The purposive criteria decide who is eligible, and convenience explains where I will find them. Neither method aims to represent all newcomer families. Together, they reach parents who can give detailed accounts of this centre's resources.

Participant Selection. If more than four eligible parents respond, I will select them in order of contact and place the others on a waitlist. Only one adult from each family will take part.

Sample Size. I will include four participants. Qualitative studies commonly use about four to eight participants so that the researcher can explore each person's experience in detail

(Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). Four participants also match the course requirement for individual projects. The findings will describe these four families' experiences and will not be generalized to all newcomer families.

Data Collection

Procedure

I will collect data through individual, semi-structured, in-depth interviews. The interview is my data collection method, and an interview protocol is my tool. The protocol will list open-ended questions with follow-up probes, and its flexible order will let me ask for more detail when a parent raises something new. I chose individual interviews over focus groups because income and subsidy are sensitive topics and families at one centre may know one another (Villamin et al., 2025). Before Week 1, I will pilot the protocol with one newcomer parent from outside the study to check its wording, translation, and length.

Each participant will take part in one meeting of about 60 to 75 minutes at a time the family chooses. Families can meet in a private room at the centre outside drop-off and pick-up times, on Zoom, or by phone. Those who join online may turn off the camera and use a pseudonym, as in Hardware et al. (2026). I will interview Mandarin speakers myself. For other languages, a trained interpreter who signs a confidentiality agreement will join, so that meaning is not lost in translation (Ilumin, 2023). Each meeting will follow three steps:

1. **Consent (about 10 minutes).** I will go through the letter of information in the parent's language and answer any questions. The parent will then sign the consent form or give recorded verbal consent.
2. **Background form (about 5 minutes).** The parent will note years in Canada, children's ages, home language, and the resources the centre offered. The form will not ask about immigration status or income.
3. **Interview (45 to 60 minutes).** With permission, I will audio record the interview. The questions will follow the three themes of my literature review. Parents will describe how they learned about a resource and what they understood about eligibility

and applying. They will explain who helped them, such as educators, settlement workers, or relatives, and what that help involved. They will talk about what led them to use or not use the resource. Finally, they will describe whether they could raise needs linked to their language and culture, how educators responded, and what they would suggest the centre change. At the end, each parent will receive the $25 gift card and a list of community supports such as EarlyON and 211 Toronto.

Taking part is voluntary. Parents may skip any question or stop the interview at any time and will still receive the gift card. They may withdraw their data within one week after their interview, before I begin coding it, and their child's care will not be affected either way. I will remove names, use pseudonyms, and keep recordings and transcripts in encrypted, password-protected files stored apart from the consent forms. Only I will hold the list that links pseudonyms to names. A small sample from one centre can make people identifiable, so my reports will not combine details such as country of origin and home language. I will also change or leave out any quotation that could identify a family (Villamin et al., 2025).

Timeline of Research Study

Table 1

Timeline of the Research Study

Period	Research activity	Main tasks
By December 2026	Ethics and preparation	Obtain ethics approval and the director's permission, translate materials, and pilot the interview protocol
Weeks 1 and 2	Recruit participants	Share the invitation, send one reminder if needed, screen parents, obtain consent, and schedule interviews
Weeks 2 and 3	Collect data	Begin interviews in Week 2, complete at least three of four (75%) by the end of Week 3, and transcribe each one soon after it ends
Week 4	Complete data collection	Conduct the last interview and begin initial coding
Week 5	Preliminary findings	Submit a summary of preliminary findings
Weeks 6 and 7	Complete analysis	Complete reflexive thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2022) and submit the findings report by Week 7
Weeks 8 and 9	Refine findings	Review and refine the findings using feedback
Week 10	Presentation draft	Complete a draft of the presentation
Weeks 11 to 13	Revise	Revise the presentation and the final report
Week 14	Final submission	Submit the final report

Ethics approval must be in place before the term begins, because recruitment starts in Week 1 and interviews begin in Week 2. I will transcribe each interview soon after it ends and start coding in Week 4, so the preliminary findings will be ready in Week 5. Throughout the study, I will record decisions, changes, and challenges in my reflexive journal.

References

Braun, V., & Clarke, V. (2022). *Thematic analysis: A practical guide*. SAGE.

Burns, S., Yu, E., Perlman, J., Kahlon, K., & Perlman, M. (2025). “It is almost impossible to get a spot when you need it”: Understanding parental knowledge and experiences of Canada’s new child care policy promoting access to quality early childhood education and care. *Early Childhood Research Quarterly, 73*, 69–81. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ecresq.2025.05.004

Canadian Institutes of Health Research, Natural Sciences and Engineering Research Council of Canada, & Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council of Canada. (2022). *Tri-Council policy statement: Ethical conduct for research involving humans – TCPS 2 (2022)*. https://ethics.gc.ca/eng/policy-politique_tcps2-eptc2_2022.html

Creswell, J. W., & Guetterman, T. C. (2019). *Educational research: Planning, conducting, and evaluating quantitative and qualitative research* (6th ed.). Pearson.

Hall, S., & Liebenberg, L. (2024). Qualitative description as an introductory method to qualitative research for master’s-level students and research trainees. *International Journal of Qualitative Methods, 23*. https://doi.org/10.1177/16094069241242264

Hardware, S., Quiogue, C., Gallo, M., & Avis, M. (2026). Let’s talk about race: The use of virtual reality in improving higher education students’ understanding of privilege. *Teaching & Learning Inquiry, 14*, 1–22. https://doi.org/10.20343/teachlearninqu.14.33

Ilumin, P. (2023). *Defining quality in early learning and childcare among visible cultural minority families in Edmonton, Alberta* [Master’s thesis, University of Alberta]. ERA. https://ualberta.scholaris.ca/items/0eb08257-1405-4722-a251-5fa8f989c99f

Massing, C., Gyan, C., Giesbrecht, C. J., Kikulwe, D., & Ghadi, N. (2024). Preferences and challenges in access to childcare programs: A mixed-methods study with newcomers to Canada. *International Journal of Early Childhood, 56*(3), 421–441. https://doi.org/10.1007/s13158-023-00375-w

Mwita, K. M. (2022). Strengths and weaknesses of qualitative research in social science studies. *International Journal of Research in Business and Social Science, 11*(6), 618–625. https://doi.org/10.20525/ijrbs.v11i6.1920

Schmidt, C. (2026). The bordering of care: How exclusions from family support programs impact undocumented mothers and their young children in Canada. *Critical Social Policy*. Advance online publication. https://doi.org/10.1177/02610183261460334

Toronto Children's Services. (2025). *Early years and child care service plan 2025–2030*. City of Toronto. https://www.toronto.ca/legdocs/mmis/2025/ec/bgrd/backgroundfile-256726.pdf

Villamin, P., Lopez, V., Thapa, D. K., & Cleary, M. (2025). A worked example of qualitative descriptive design: A step-by-step guide for novice and early career researchers. *Journal of Advanced Nursing, 81,* 5181–5195. https://doi.org/10.1111/jan.16481